

**The South Side Over a Decade:
Data, Change, and the Reputation-Reality Gap**

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DSA400W

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The Southside has a reputation. Walk into any conversation about Pittsburgh neighborhoods and you will hear the South Side is chaotic, dangerous, a party place, and an ideology about being "on the correct side of the bridge". College students, nightlife, bars are the images that stick. When we set out to do this project, we knew that narrative, it's everywhere.

For people who live there, work there, and study there, the story does not match what we hear. Safe childhoods, going to elementary school, quiet nights, a neighborhood that felt stable and safe to live in. Tell this to most people, and you can see the surprise and disbelief on their faces, the surprise, skepticism and biases they hold. There is a disconnect between what people think the South Side must be and what the people actually living there know it to be.

Looking at ten years (2016 to 2026) of data does not replace that lived experience, but reveals patterns instead of just assumptions. It shows what really changed, what stayed the same, and what the data does or does not show. The question we are asking is: can we understand the South Side by looking at crime, housing, air quality, and community spaces together? What does the data actually show when we stop relying on reputation

Introduction

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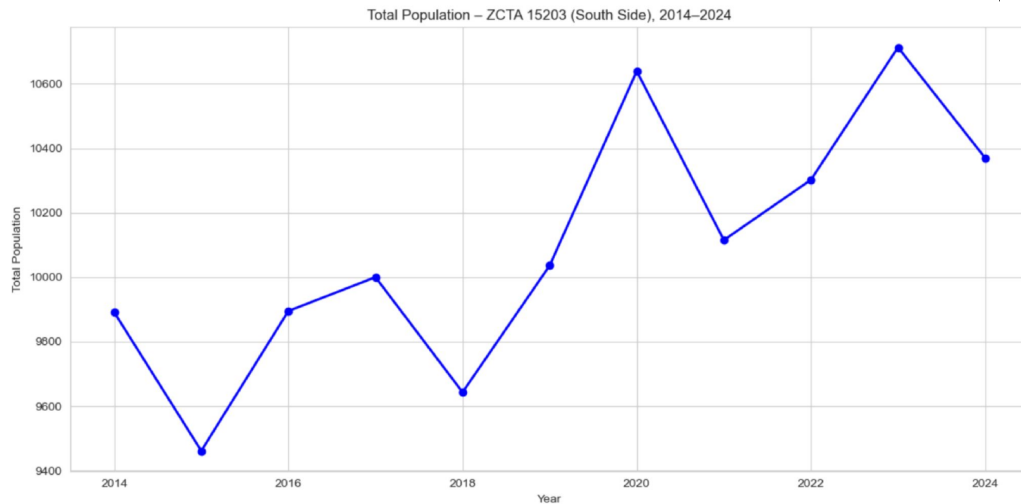
Note on the data: the primary window for this analysis is 2016 to 2026, covering a decade of crime, housing, development, air quality, and community data. The one exception is the population and poverty section, which draws on U.S. Census data spanning 2014 to 2024. This is because that ten-year census window represents the cleanest and most complete data available for demographic analysis of the South Side. All other sections remain within the 2016 to 2026 frame.

Part I: Who Lives On the South Side; Understanding the Neighborhood

Population

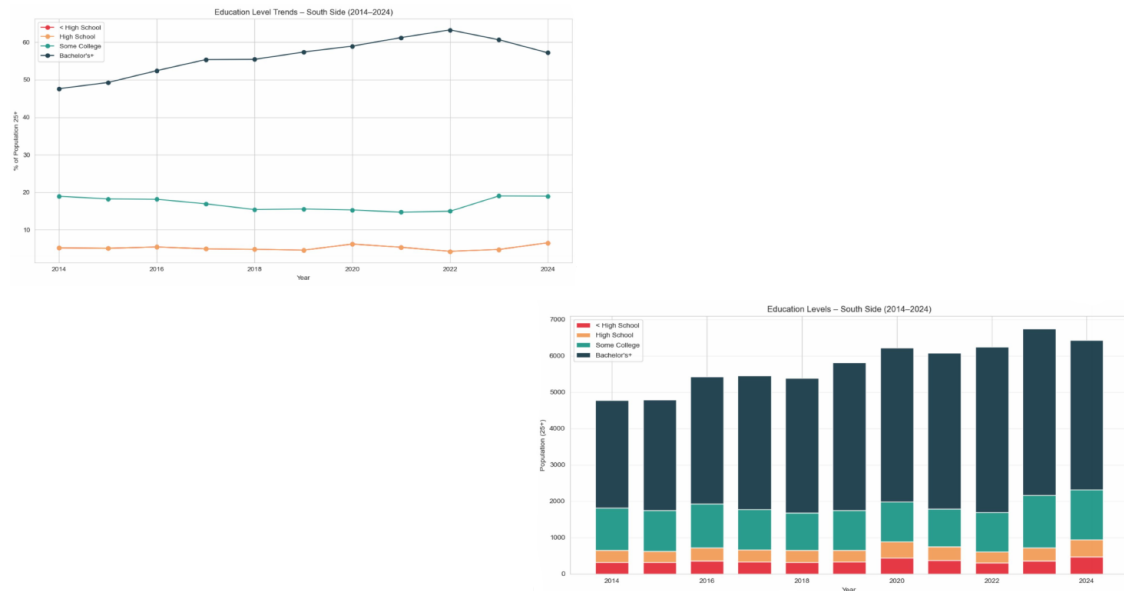
Before diving into the stories the data tells about crime, housing, and development, we need to understand who actually lives on the South Side. The population tells us something fundamental about the neighborhood that the reputation completely misses.

Population Stability and Growth



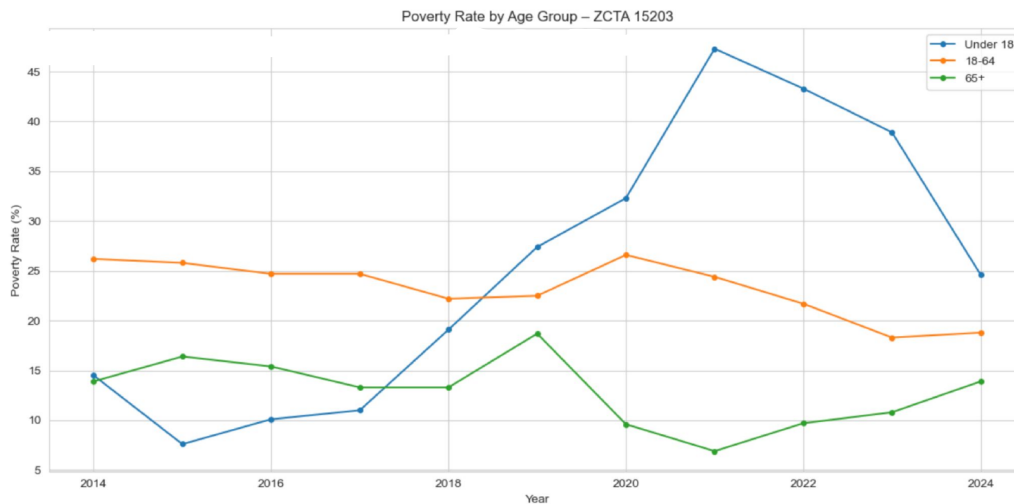
Over the decade from 2014 to 2024, the South Side population grew from around 9,900 residents to roughly 10,400, a modest 5% increase. This has not been a straight line. There was a dip to around 9,450 in 2015, another dip to about 9,650 in 2018, and then a sharp jump to over 10,600 by 2020. This tells us people are moving in and out; the neighborhood is not stagnant, it is in flux. Despite the reputation as a place people just pass through on a Saturday night, more people are actually choosing to live here now than a decade ago.

Education Levels Rising



This is one of the most telling statistics. Over half the adults in the South Side hold a bachelor's degree or higher. In 2014, this share was about 47%. By 2023, it had grown to roughly 55%. Meanwhile, the population with less than a high school education has stayed flat at around 7 to 9%. This is not the uneducated party district people imagine. The South Side is increasingly a college-educated neighborhood, which aligns with the influx of young professionals, not just transient students.

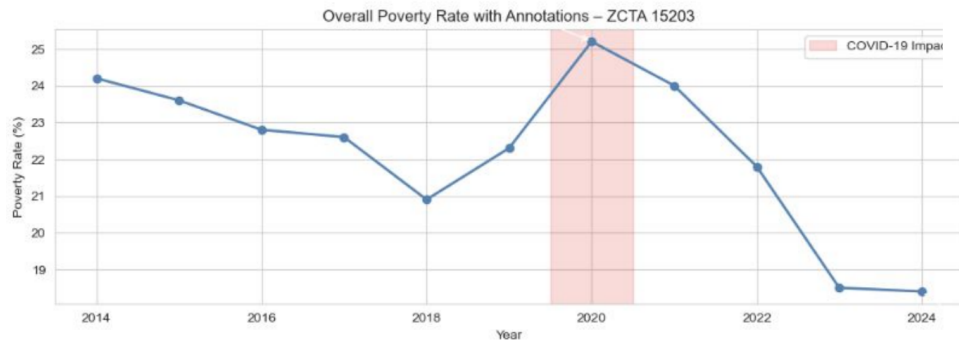
The Child Poverty Crisis



Here is what demands attention: child poverty in the South Side spiked dramatically during the decade we studied. Under-18 poverty started around 14% in 2014, dipped as low as 7% in 2015, then exploded to nearly 47% by 2021, almost half of the children in the South Side living below the poverty line. It came back down to about 25% by 2024, but that is still nearly double what it was a decade ago.

Meanwhile, the working-age population (18 to 64) has stayed relatively stable around 22 to 25% poverty rate, and seniors 65-plus have actually seen their poverty rate drop from 16% down to around 10 to 14%. The takeaway is stark: the people being hit hardest by poverty in this neighborhood are kids, and that story is completely invisible in the bars-and-nightlife narrative.

Overall Poverty Trend



Overall poverty had been on a steady decline from about 24% in 2014 down to 21% by 2018, which represents real progress. Then COVID hit. Poverty spiked back up to over 25% in 2020, the highest point in the entire decade. But here is the good news: after COVID, it dropped sharply, all the way down to under 19% by 2023, which is the lowest poverty rate the South Side has seen in at least 10 years. So the long-term trend is actually positive. The South Side is getting less poor over time, but COVID was a real setback, especially for the most vulnerable residents.

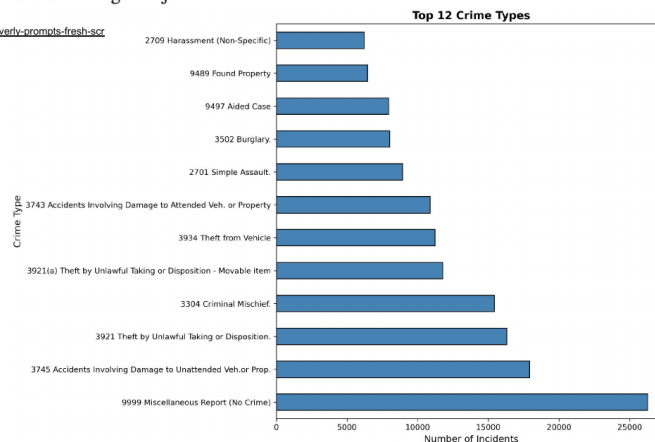
Part II: Crime and Safety; The Reputation Foundation

Overall Picture: Stability and Fluctuation

Pittsburgh police Monday said officers this past weekend made nine arrests in South Side's entertainment district, which they started patrolling aggressively in 2023. They also made 17 traffic stops and handed out 26 non-traffic citations, many for carrying open containers of alcohol in public or smoking marijuana.

"But, if you compare what's going on now to 2020 through 2022, it's a different ballgame," he added. "We've just got to keep working on it. It's a continuing work in progress."

<https://triblive.com/local/south-sides-late-night-revery-prompts-fresh-scrutiny-and-familiar-fears/>

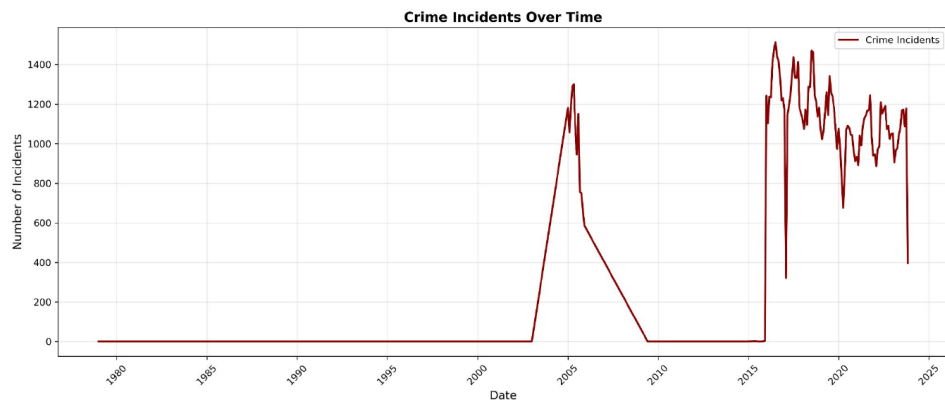


When we looked at crime data for the South Side over ten years, we found something that does not fit the reputation. Crime incidents show a consistent pattern from 2016 onward: roughly 1,200 to 1,500 incidents per quarter. Then 2020 hit, the pandemic disrupted everything, and crime dropped to about 650 incidents. But here is what matters: by 2023, crime had fallen again to around 350 incidents. If someone tells you crime on the South Side is "out of control," this data says otherwise. The recent trend is actually downward.

This matters because it shows the neighborhood does not have a perpetual crisis. Crime fluctuates, seasonally and over years, but it is not a straight line upward. Some months are busy while some are quiet. Crime, as we know, is not consistent. This is important because it means the narrative people carry might be missing the actual lived reality of how the neighborhood functions most of the time.

So what does this mean for how we understand the South Side? If crime fluctuates predictably and is actually declining, does that change how we should think about neighborhood safety? Is a neighborhood that oscillates between peaks and valleys fundamentally different from one in perpetual crisis? What would we need to know to decide if this pattern is acceptable or if something needs to change?

Crime Type Matters: What Police Actually Respond To

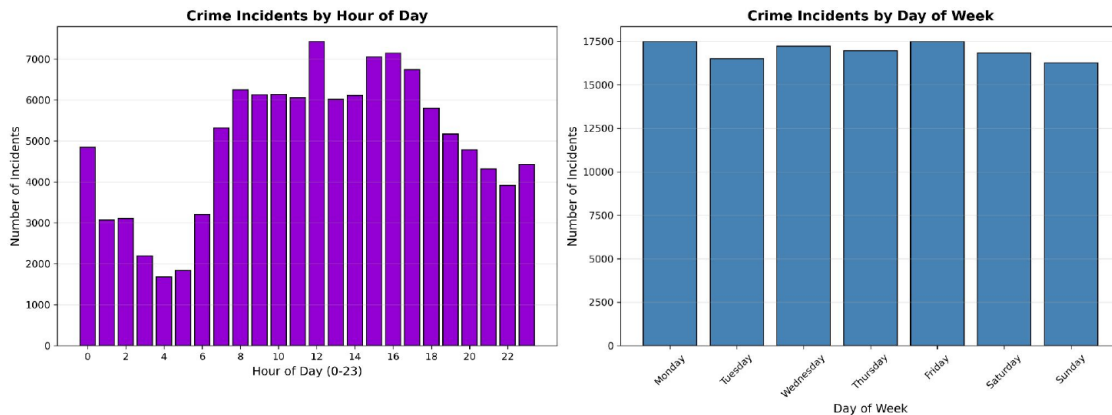


When we break down what police actually respond to, the picture gets even more complicated. The single largest category, by far, is "Miscellaneous Report: No Crime," at about 25,000 entries. That means the number-one thing police respond to on the South Side is not even a crime. After that, the top categories are vehicle accidents, theft, and criminal mischief, not violent crime. Simple assault ranks 6th on the list at roughly 7,000 incidents.

The South Side is not, in fact, uniform. Property crimes (theft, burglary, larceny) dominate the actual crime categories. This makes sense for a neighborhood laden with bars, restaurants, lots of foot traffic, and a transient population. Violence (crimes categorized as assaults or robberies) happens, but far less than reputation might suggest. Other crimes (minor infractions, quality of life complaints) add up, too. The problem is the broad label of "crime on the South Side" erases all these differences. A neighborhood with lots of theft feels different than a neighborhood with lots of violence. Both sound "dangerous" or "unstable" if you lump them together. But they are actually different situations with vastly different root causes and different implications for how people actually experience the neighborhood. This specificity matters a lot; what crime is committed and when changes the data-driven view entirely.

How would understanding the neighborhood safety change if we stopped talking about "crime on the South Side" as one general item? What if we acknowledged that property crime and violent crime demand different attention? If most crime is theft rather than assault, the data shows us that the actual risks residents face are not the same as the reputation would have you believe.

Temporal Patterns: When Crime Happens Reveals Logic



Here is where our findings surprised us. Crime does not peak in the evening and at night the way you would expect from an entertainment district reputation. Instead, crime incidents peak around noon at approximately 7,300 incidents. There is a late-night bump around midnight at about 5,000, but the afternoon hours between noon and 4 PM consistently outpace the nighttime.

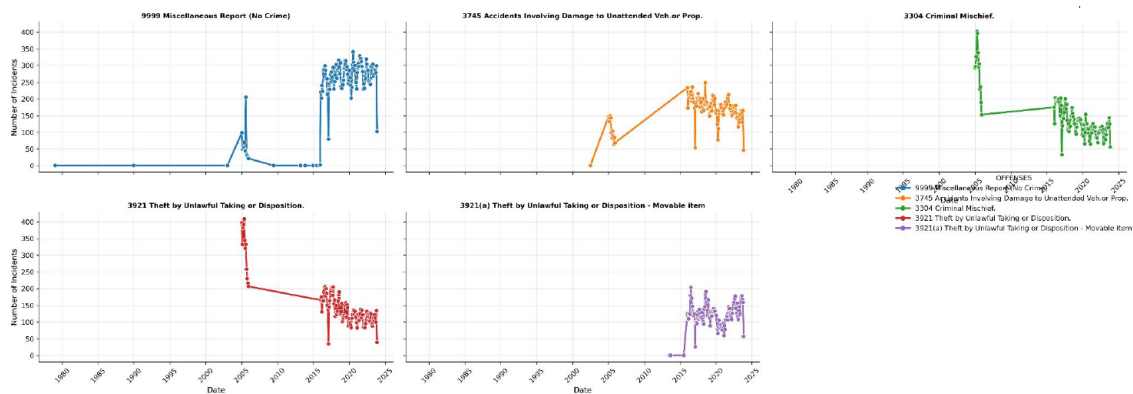
When we looked at crime by day of the week, the pattern was almost completely flat, ranging from about 16,500 to 17,500 incidents across all seven days. Friday and Monday are slightly higher, but Saturday, the supposed worst night for an entertainment district, is not even at the top. Crime on the South Side is not primarily a weekend-nightlife problem. It is spread evenly across the entire week and peaks during the day.

This is a critical insight because it does not match the entertainment district stereotype. The distribution suggests that much of what is being reported as "crime" is daytime incidents, traffic issues, petty disputes, quality-of-life complaints, not the bar-district violence the reputation implies. But when reports say "the South Side has a crime problem," they are not usually thinking about this context. They are just hearing about

crime and attaching it to reputation. The disconnect between what we found and how people talk about it became a central question for us.

If the South Side crime profile differs from expected entertainment district patterns in these ways, does that matter? Does it change whether it is a problem? With our data, we believe there is complexity here: the choice to have an entertainment district is also a choice to have certain patterns of police responses and incident reporting, but those patterns may not align with actual threats to safety.

Crime Types Over Time: Which Are Changing?



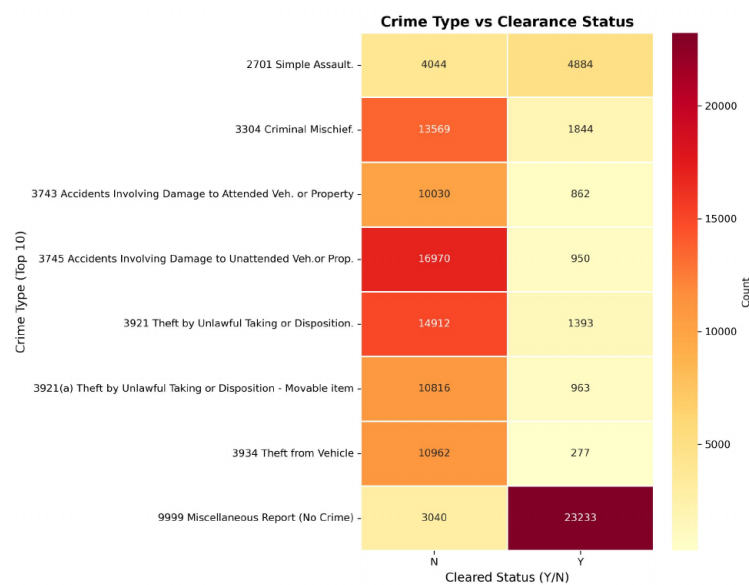
Property crime dominates overall. But different crimes do not follow the same trajectory. Some are going down, some are going up, and others bounce around with no clear pattern. This means that there is no single South Side crime trend. Theft might be declining while one category of incident is rising. Different problems with different causes need different solutions.

When you say "crime is on the rise" or "crime is on the decline," you miss what is actually happening. Each category has its own story, and they do not move together. The problem we encounter is that the data cannot tell you which specific crime types are driven by what causes. Maybe police responses have changed. Maybe police staffing has changed. Maybe there is policing in the entertainment strip only on the weekends. Maybe

something really did get worse. The data alone does not answer these questions. This limitation matters; we have to be honest about what the data can actually tell us.

So what information do we need that we cannot simply derive from the data? But what other information would we need to understand whether the South Side is getting safer, less safe, or just different?

Who Solves What? Crime Type vs. Clearance Status



Some crimes do eventually get marked "cleared", meaning they could have been solved, led to an arrest, or been found to be unsolvable. Other cases are designated to be open cases forever. From the data, we see that clearance rates vary dramatically by crime type. Property crimes have shockingly low clearance rates: Theft from Vehicle has a 2.5% solve rate (277 cleared out of 11,239 total); Theft by Unlawful Taking is roughly 9% (1,393 cleared out of 16,305 total); Criminal Mischief is roughly 12% (1,844 cleared out of 15,413 total). Across the board, 85 to 95% of property crimes on the South Side go unsolved. Crimes with eyewitnesses or clear suspects get solved more often, while

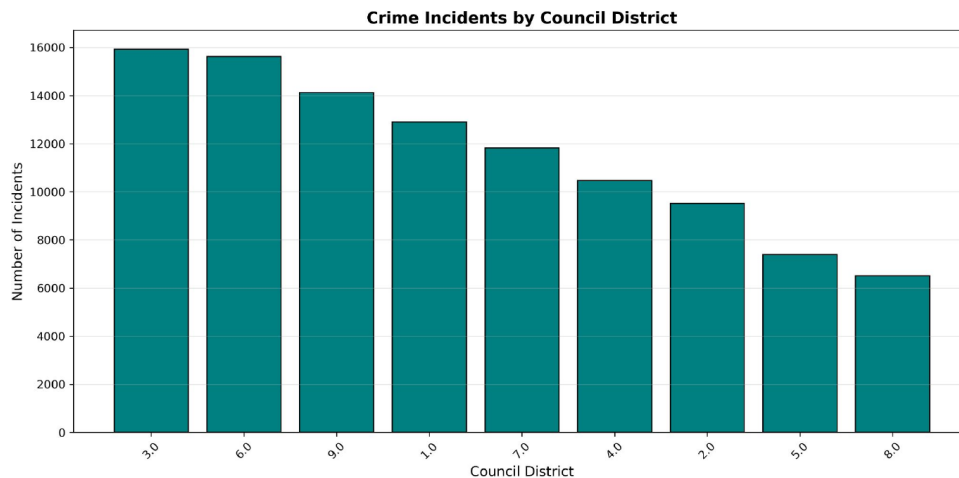
solving crimes like a burglary takes investigation, time, and resources. Most police departments do not have the time or resources, so items like stolen bikes join thousands of other unsolved cases.

The one bright spot is Simple Assault, about 4,000 unsolved versus nearly 4,900 cleared, meaning assaults actually get resolved more than 50% of the time. But the biggest number on the whole chart is Miscellaneous Reports cleared at 23,233, which are not even violent crimes.

For the South Side, property crimes dominate. Which means most crime is not getting solved. People are experiencing theft, and no action from the police seems to happen. This feels unaccountable, like minor crimes do not matter. The good news is that this is not a problem isolated to the South Side, the greater Pittsburgh area, or further; it is an unfortunate symptom of policing everywhere. The bad news is that while this is a general problem with policing, it is very real for the occupants of the South Side. Your stuff gets stolen, the police take a report, and nothing comes of it. We kept coming back to this: the system itself creates a gap between what people experience and what gets addressed.

If property crime accounts for most incidents on the South Side, but most property crimes never get solved, what does that tell residents about whether the system cares about their experience? Does an unresolved theft feel like a public safety issue or like being abandoned by a system? We need to dive deeper into how this shapes how people understand safety differently than crime statistics alone suggest.

Geographic Variation: The District Matters



Crime is not evenly spread out across the South Side. Some blocks have way more incidents than others. When we look at Pittsburgh council districts, the South Side (Council District 3) shows the highest incident count at around 16,000. But look at District 6 right behind it at about 15,500, and District 9 at around 14,000. The difference between the top and middle districts is not that dramatic. The South Side is not an outlier; it is at the top, but barely. Multiple districts across Pittsburgh have comparable crime volumes.

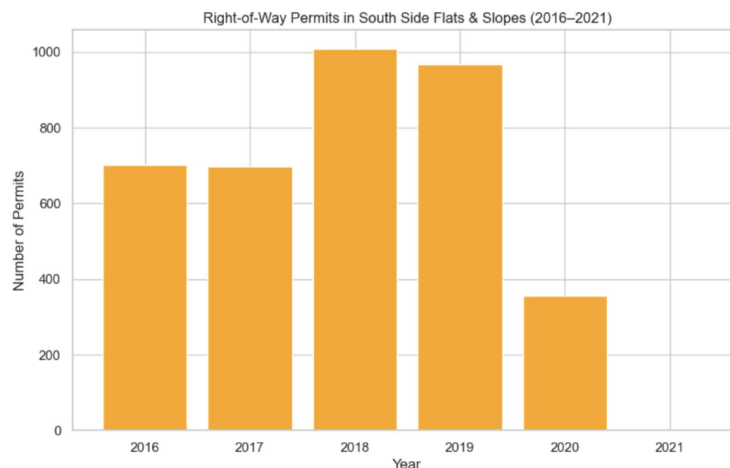
More bars and restaurants and foot traffic mean more incidents get reported. More students in certain spots change crime patterns. More police presence in entertainment areas means more minor incidents and charges get documented. When we follow a narrative of "the South Side", we are flattening a neighborhood that is actually many different areas. Someone living three blocks away from the main bar strip experiences a totally different place than someone right in the middle of it. Same zip code, but different realities. The data presented as neighborhood-wide averages obscure this. We realized

this, too, is crucial. You cannot treat the South Side as one place when the actual experience depends much more on where you are.

If crime varies dramatically within the South Side depending on location, does a neighborhood-level statistic even mean anything when it comes to someone trying to decide if the area is safe? What if residents in quiet residential blocks are getting branded with crime statistics from the entertainment district a few blocks away? How would the neighborhood conversation change if we acknowledged that geography determines experiences more than reputation?

Part III: Development, Housing, and Physical Change

The Development Story: Permits as a Window into Neighborhood Change



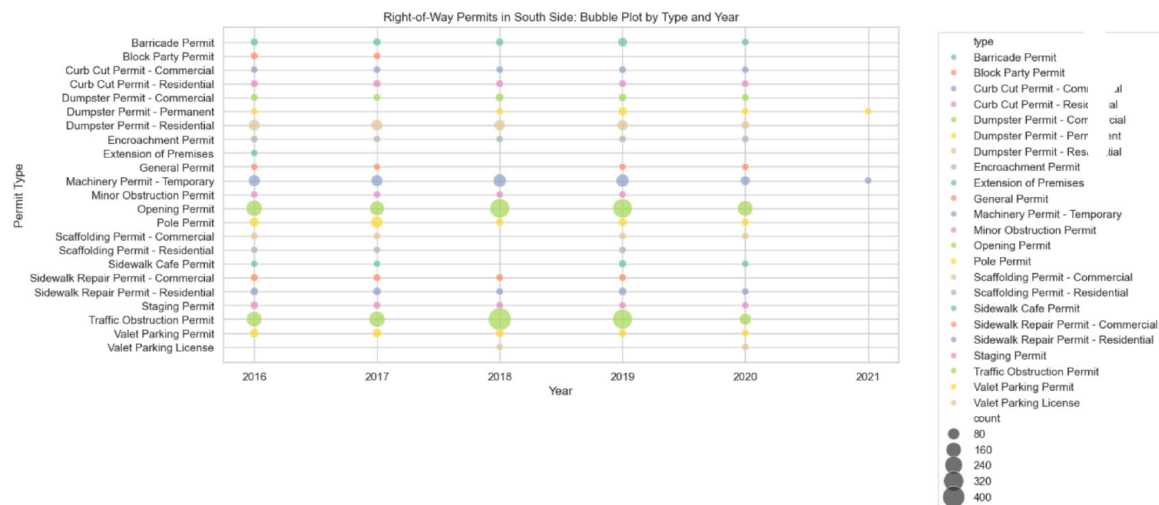
Over the last decade, there have been consistent changes in the physical environment in the South Side community that can easily be missed when looking at the statistics of the area crime or nightlife. Permits reveal a community that has continually been under development, with structures being rehabilitated and infrastructure being improved upon. This is definitely not a community that has been stagnant throughout the years.

The most significant trend in this timeline is the peak of the permitting period in 2018 and 2019. This is the period where investment was at its peak, and where building and other infrastructure activities took place at an all-time high. Be it the efforts of private investors to remodel old buildings or those of the municipal government to update the utilities, there was a flurry of activity in the South Side that shaped future developments in subsequent years. The peak was followed by consistent levels of permitting activities. However, this degree of development creates some crucial questions regarding what type of neighborhood the South Side is becoming. While the process of urban development is positive, at the same time, it might lead to some additional changes, including rising prices, migration, and social problems for the existing inhabitants. In fact, the statistics provide us with proof of development itself rather than of its outcomes, but still, one cannot deny the fact that the South Side is actively developing.

Beyond crime, something else has been happening on the Southside. The neighborhood is being built up. Renovated. Changed physically. We looked at permit data to see who got permits, what kind of work, when. The permits fluctuate. Around 2018 to 2019 there is a spike when development really cranked up. Overall the message is clear: this neighborhood is not frozen. It is actively changing. But development is not neutral. Money being invested is good. Infrastructure being improved is good. But development also displaces people. Rents go up. Longtime residents get pushed out. The permits show the development. They do not show the displacement. Both are happening simultaneously.

If the Southside is becoming a different neighborhood, with more students, higher rents, and renovated buildings, what happens to the people who were there before? Should that influence how we evaluate whether development is "good"?

Right-of-Way Permits: Infrastructure as Development Indicator



Right-of-way permits provide insight into the type of work that is occurring within the community. Right-of-way permits include anything related to work in the public domain, including road closures, pedestrian work, utility repair work, and temporary construction facilities. When analyzing the types of permits that were issued, a clear trend emerges: The South Side is consistently under construction.

Traffic obstruction permits are the biggest category, accounting for temporary street use during construction and events. Opening/closing permits come next, covering utility and infrastructure work. Then machinery and temporary facilities permits, followed by demolition permits and utility pole work. There is a big spike around 2018 to 2019 when development activity really cranked up. After that it levels off, but infrastructure activity stays steady year to year.

The constant flow of permits means the streets are always busy, with construction, utility upgrades, and infrastructure maintenance. The city or private companies are consistently putting money into fixing and building things. This constant infrastructure activity means more construction, and we see trends towards more street disruption, noise, and inconvenience. While this infrastructure activity does mean improved utilities and roads, it can also signal to residents that this infrastructure is aging and needs constant replacement rather than being newly built. The permits show activity is happening, but not whether that activity is solving problems or masking deeper aging infrastructure issues.

Traffic obstruction permits far outweigh the next two types of permits. Therefore, there is consistently work occurring on public streets that involves street obstruction, excavation, and routing. As such, it is fair to suggest that the neighborhood is consistently being developed. It is unclear whether the development is positive, negative, or both. However, it does provide opportunities for developers and the city government.

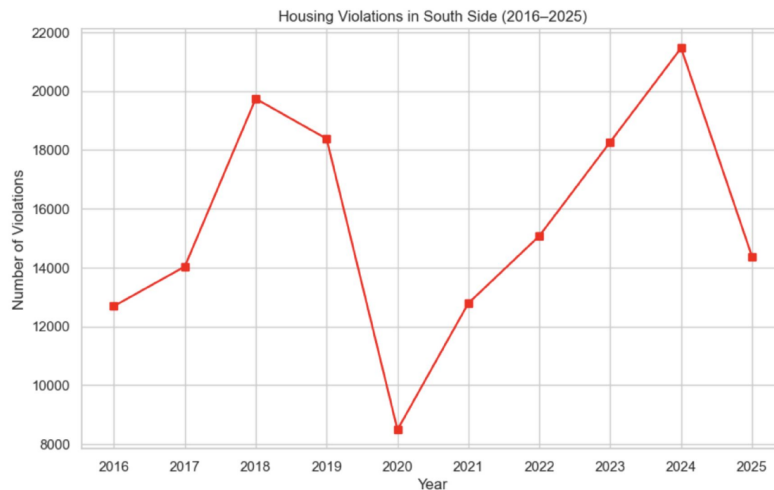
This is a complicated issue because it could indicate that the South Side has received attention from both the city and investors. It could also mean that this is an area where new populations are expected to arrive shortly after development occurs. Unfortunately, there is no clear way to determine whether this is the case or not from this particular set of data. They do not show whether that activity makes the neighborhood better for existing residents or whether it is preparing the neighborhood for new residents with higher incomes who will replace them.

We realize this is where the abstract development story becomes personal. If the infrastructure is constantly being upgraded and maintained, are those updates benefiting

the people currently living there, or are they making the neighborhood more attractive for displacement? It seems clear that more research should be done to understand whether infrastructure investments improve a neighborhood for existing residents or accelerate gentrification.

Part IV: Housing Conditions and Community Health

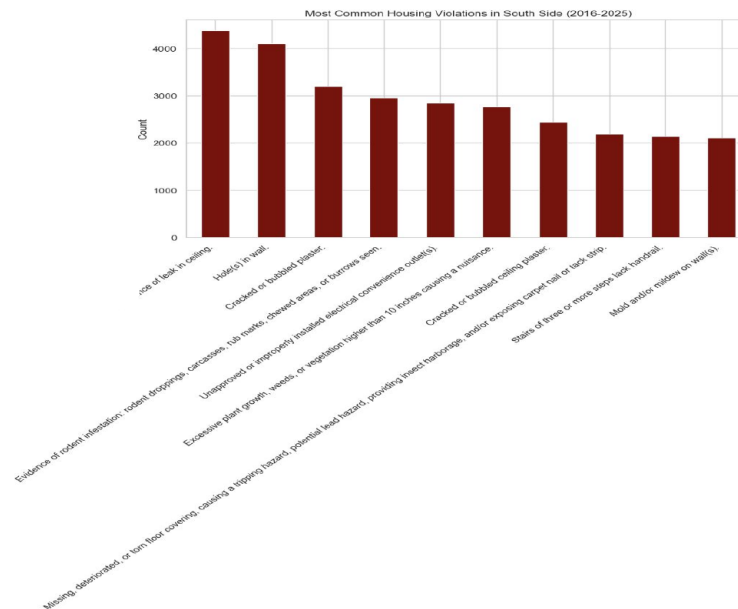
Housing Violations: Keeping Pace with Growth



As the South Side has developed and grown, housing conditions have become a measure of neighborhood health. Housing violations provide insight into the realities that face the residents of the South Side. They are when the city finds code violations, maintenance problems, and places that are not safe to live in. The pattern is striking.

Starting around 12,800 violations in 2016, they climbed steadily. By 2018 they hit nearly 20,000. Then something dramatic happened in 2020, violations dropped to just 8,600. The reason seems to be clear: the pandemic. There was little to no enforcement, buildings were not being inspected, and violations were not being documented. But starting in 2021, violations climbed again. By 2024, housing violations hit 21,500, which is the

highest on record in this ten year period. By 2025, they had dropped slightly to around 14,500, but the overall message is clear: violations are back up and staying high.

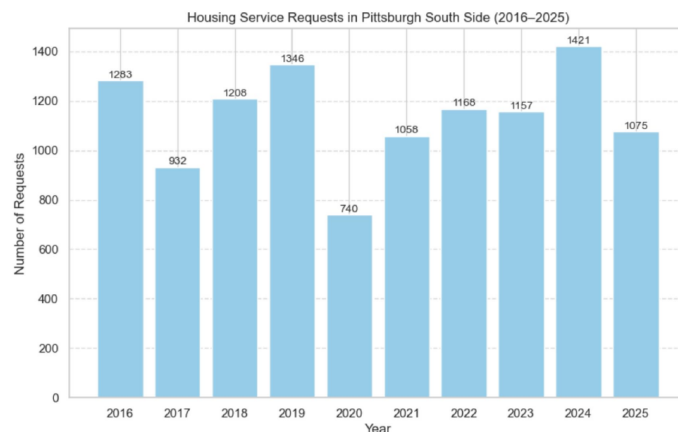


What are these violations about? The data is quite telling here. Water intrusion dominated at around 4,500 violations: leaks, moisture damage, and water getting into walls. These are the kinds of problems that come from roofs failing or pipes leaking. Health hazards in units account for around 4,100 violations: things that make apartments unsafe. Cracked and broken plaster account for around 3,200 violations: structural deterioration. Deficient or improper heating accounts for around 2,900 violations: apartments that are cold in winter. There are more: electrical issues, plumbing problems, and habitability concerns. But the pattern is unmistakable. The violations cluster around moisture, maintenance, and heating. These are typical problems of old buildings that have not been maintained well. Buildings that are aging without investment. When you do not fix the roof, water gets in. When you do not maintain systems, they fail. When you do not invest in basic upkeep, everything degrades.

What is happening here is complicated. The spike to 21,500 in 2024 could mean conditions are actually getting worse. Or it could mean the city finally started enforcing seriously after years of backlogs. Probably both. The pandemic disrupted everything; violations were not recorded, enforcement stopped, and the baseline shifted. Then, when inspections resumed, problems had accumulated. But whatever the cause, the people living in these places feel it. Cold apartments. Moisture damage. Mold. Landlords do not fix things. Tenants cannot force them without risking eviction. It is a real problem.

We kept thinking about what these violation types mean in terms of actual human experience, not just numbers, but cold apartments in winter, mold in walls, water damage everywhere. If development is driving rents up while housing quality problems are increasing to record levels and concentrating on moisture, heating, and basic maintenance, what happens to residents caught in the middle? Should development in a neighborhood require housing quality to improve, not decline? What if growth and housing problems both accelerate at the same time, what does that tell us about where the development is actually benefiting someone?

Housing Service Requests: Residents Taking Action



Another way to measure housing problems is to count how many times people call the city asking for help. Housing service requests show residents and landlords actively trying to address issues. Someone notices a problem, cold apartment, leak, broken window, and files a complaint. The pattern is revealing.

Requests fluctuate year to year, but the consistent pattern shows that residents are filing over 1,000 service requests nearly every year. In 2023, requests hit a peak of 1,421. These requests show people are actively trying to fix their situations. But the sheer volume suggests this is an ongoing, persistent concern. Not something sitting quietly. It is something residents are pushing back on.

Why does it vary so much year to year? Maybe more people know they can file complaints. Maybe word spread that the city handles them faster. Maybe housing problems are just different year to year. Maybe in some years people give up and stop trying. The variation is hard to interpret. But here is what matters: residents are consistently trying to get help. They are taking action. They are not accepting bad housing conditions passively.

Yet the requests and violations tell different stories. When inspections were disrupted in 2020 and barely happening, requests dropped to their lowest point, but violations also dropped artificially to just 8,600 because buildings were not being inspected. In 2023, requests hit a peak of 1,421 at the same time violations were rising significantly to over 15,000. This gap, between how many problems residents report and how many violations the city finds, is significant.

We realized this gap is really important. People are asking for help. The city is finding problems. But something in the middle is not connecting. If residents are actively

requesting help but violations keep increasing, what does that tell us? Are city resources not keeping up with the problems? Are complaints coming from a shrinking group of people while others give up after repeated failures? What would need to happen to shift from residents fighting individual battles to actual systemic improvement?

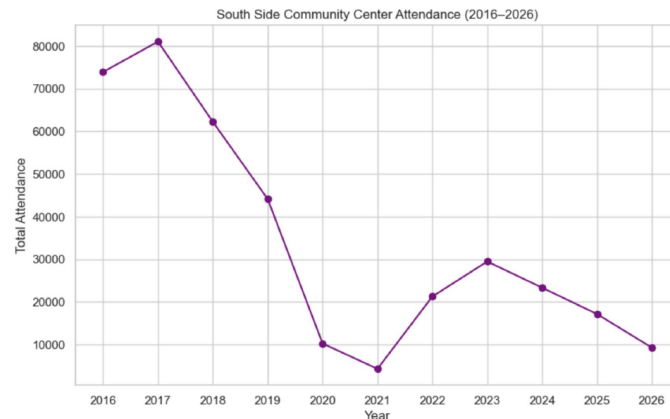
The Housing-Violation Dynamic: What Enforcement Tells Us

When we looked at violations and service requests together, something interesting emerged. Sometimes violations spike while requests drop. Sometimes the reverse. These two numbers measure different things. Requests show what residents and landlords are actively complaining about. Violations show what the city actually finds when they inspect. In recent years, both have been elevated. People are calling for help. The city is finding violations. That points to real, documented problems. But it also shows a gap: people want help and the problems exist, but something in between is not connecting. Either the complaints are not being addressed fast enough, or the problems are too big, or some combination. We found ourselves asking: is the system broken, are resources inadequate, or do we need different approaches entirely?

When residents report problems and the city documents violations but conditions still decline, what does that reveal about how neighborhood improvement actually works? Is the system itself broken? Are resources inadequate? Do we need different approaches entirely? What would it take to shift from documenting problems to actually solving them?

Part V: Community Life and Civic Engagement

Community Center Attendance: The South Side Social Infrastructure



Community centers can be overlooked when discussing the development of neighborhoods, yet they are among the most evident markers of how invested people are in their community. These centers cater to all ages, including families, youth, elderly people, and those seeking services and programs. In contrast to nightclubs and bars, community centers represent the silent and daily existence of a community that never makes news but is very significant to its inhabitants. The South Side has a few options for this. While a lot of these programs either do not have data or are too new to have enough data yet, one that we can look at in detail is the Community Center.

The attendance data shows there has been a drastic reduction in the numbers of attendance in the past ten years. Looking at the detailed year-by-year breakdown: 2016 had around 74,000 visits; 2017 peaked at 80,000 (the highest in the entire decade); 2018 declined to 62,000; 2019 further declined to 44,000; 2020 brought pandemic lockdowns and collapsed to 10,000; 2021 hit rock bottom at 5,000 (center was essentially closed); 2022 to 2023 brought a brief recovery with some people returning; 2026 was back down

to around 10,000. The overall collapse from peak to present: 87% decline from 80,000 to 10,000 visitors annually.

Here is what is critical: this decline did not start with the pandemic. It began before COVID hit. In fact, the center was already experiencing sustained decline from 2017 through 2019, dropping from 80,000 to 44,000 before lockdowns even happened. The pandemic accelerated the collapse, but it did not cause it. Even after restrictions were lifted and society reopened, attendance never recovered to pre-pandemic levels. That tells us something structural changed, either in the neighborhood, in how people use spaces, or in what the center offers.

The reason for such a dramatic pre-pandemic decline likely lies in demographic changes in the area. There is evidence of fewer families and longtime residents utilizing the services in the center. It is worth noting that there are demographic changes in the area because of an increase in rent rates, students, and population turnover. Community centers depend on stable and reliable residents who intend to live permanently in the region, have children, and grow old within the same place.

This downward trend is also associated with changes in the way individuals participate in the neighborhood social life. As developments continue to rise and housing becomes worse, the social fabric that enables individuals to come together, participate in activities, and form relationships does not develop at the same pace. The South Side might become more developed physically; however, it is losing its communal nature, which allows individuals to get involved in events happening in the area.

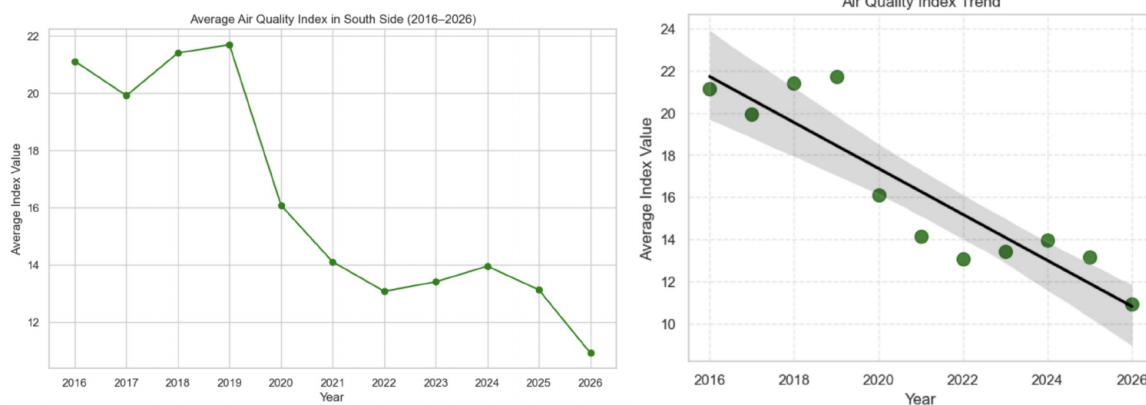
This downward trend is significant in terms of what it implies regarding the nature of the South Side community. According to the research data, the community has a rich history

and has been quite active. Tens of thousands of visits per year used to take place at the community center annually, proving that this area was used not only for entertainment purposes but also as a location where individuals could come together and participate in communal life.

What is happening is a critical loss: A community institution that had 80,000 visits a year is now basically empty. A community center packed and healthy is a place where residents have collective power. They can push together. Make noise. Demand action. When that institution collapses, that power disappears. Housing problems persist. But residents lose the mechanism to collectively fight back.

Part VI: Environmental Quality and Public Health

Air Quality Improvement: A Quiet but Significant Shift



While the narrative of tension on the South Side in recent years has been one filled with increasing housing violations, reduced community participation, and ongoing construction, the data of air quality over this period speaks to an opposite story that deserves attention. Over the past decade, the air quality on the South Side improved consistently and significantly.

In just a decade, the value of the Air Quality Index (AQI) on the South Side dropped from about 21 to 11, a 50% improvement. The drop by a factor of two signifies that the air on the South Side became almost twice as clean within ten years. An AQI reading of 21 indicates poor air due to particulate matter, which can be dangerous for asthmatic individuals and children. An AQI of 11 is significantly healthier.

The reason why this development is rather remarkable is because this takes place against a background of stereotypes associated with South Side nightlife, cars, and noise. In popular imagination, the area is thought of as being quite noisy and polluted, but the facts show that the trend is going in the other direction. While the South Side remains as lively as ever in terms of bars and restaurants on weekends, its overall environment continues to improve, getting cleaner air along the way.

A number of factors can contribute to such developments. For example, lower emissions across the region because of modernized vehicles, stricter rules at factories, and changes in energy production should be noted. There may even be construction-related reasons for cleaner air. Newer buildings with better utilities should theoretically mean fewer leaks and less pollution. Another contributing factor might be the pandemic, which decreased traffic significantly. Regardless of the causes behind this change, however, one thing is clear: South Side has cleaner air now than a decade ago.

This development brings a new dimension to the story of transformation in the neighborhood. As deterioration in housing conditions and lack of participation by the community in activities are evident, there have been subtle changes in environmental conditions. This proves that transformations in the South Side are not unidirectional and one-sided but involve a mix of positive and negative changes. The difficult part lies in

comprehending how all these dimensions influence each other and whether improvements in the environment have equal impact on all segments of the population.

As an investigation into the dimensions of change and continuity, the findings of air quality in this study provide some significant insights for us. Change and continuity in neighborhoods may not always be visible and evident. The most effective changes can take place without much ado or fuss and remain unnoticed unless we analyze the data collected in detail.

Part VII: What the Data Cannot Tell Us

Before jumping to conclusions, it is important to understand what the data cannot tell us and why it might be underrepresented. Not everything gets reported equally. A broken window in a bar might be documented, but the same problem at a personal residence is not treated the same way. With more police present in an entertainment district, more minor items are catalogued.

Crime data shows reported incidents, not arrests or convictions. Someone robs a store on the South Side, and that is reported. But the robber might be from somewhere else entirely. This holds true for the number of people who come to the South Side specifically for nightlife and, in a drunken state, rack up the incident rate. The data does not tell us if residents are the problem or if it is visitors. Some crimes get "cleared," which means not much when looking at the number of charges, as many cases also stay open. The clearance rate partly measures police resources. A low clearance rate does not mean the crime did not happen or was not serious. It might just mean the police do not have time to solve it, which does tie into the truth about the policing gaps and numbers within the city, a city-wide problem.

Housing violations depend on someone inspecting buildings, and a building with serious problems might go uninspected for years. Housing service requests depend on people knowing they can file them and being willing to. Lots of people do not know, and even more people might fear retaliation if they do complain. Both these numbers might be incomplete due to that. Permits show development, but when development brings rising rents and longtime residents get pushed out, and it seems clear that has been happening, that displacement is not represented in the data we have access to. Parking in particular has been a large issue on the South Side, with many residents having to appeal to those corporations and face long arbitration periods on this matter.

Although the air quality trends show improvement, the data does not provide information on the reasons for those improvements and their sustainability. While the visualizations highlight the overall change, it fails to account for the reasons for improved air quality or if it can maintain its upward trajectory. It also does not mention who experiences better conditions, despite the improved statistics at the neighborhood level. It is unclear how individuals residing close to highways, entertainment districts, or sites undergoing construction are impacted. The data is averaged, which means short-term spikes in pollution levels are not captured, hence residents cannot use the information provided to track any improvements in air quality at the neighborhood level. Finally, the positive trend might result from regional policies, such as the transition to electric cars or changes in manufacturing practices, so it is not possible to determine whether the South Side is directly responsible for the results or if they can be undone due to increasing density.

The data shows trends, not the causes, the uneven impacts, or the live reality behind it.

The COVID-19 Disruption: Understanding Data Artifacts vs. True Trends

Here is the honest part. When you have data spanning 2016 to 2026, you run into a fundamental problem: 2020 to 2021 does not represent normal years. They represent a year when the entire system changed, not because of underlying neighborhood trends, but because a global pandemic disrupted how we measure things. This is critical to understanding the data properly.

Crime data shows reported incidents, but in 2020, there were fewer people on streets due to lockdowns, so reported crime dropped to around 650 from 1,200 to 1,500. That is not because the South Side got safer; it is because lockdowns meant fewer opportunities for crime to happen and fewer witnesses. Fewer bars open. Fewer people walking the streets. Fewer reports. When you look at our crime chart and see the 2020 dip, you are seeing a data artifact, not a neighborhood trend.

Housing inspections tell a similar but more important story: in 2016 to 2019, violations were documented regularly. Then 2020 hit and inspectors stopped going into buildings. Violations dropped to 8,600, the lowest point in our entire decade, but this does not mean housing got better. Buildings were still deteriorating. Water was still leaking. Nobody was just documenting it. When inspections resumed in 2021, violations spiked: 2022 brought increases, 2023 brought further increases, and 2024 hit 21,500, the highest in the decade. Why? The city was finding years of accumulated problems hidden during the pandemic.

So the dramatic spike from 2020 to 2024 is both real deterioration AND a backlog effect; you cannot compare pre-2020 housing data to post-2021 data because the measurement

itself changed. The conditions were getting worse the whole time; we just were not documenting them.

Community center attendance tells a related but different story. The decline from 80,000 (2017 peak) to 44,000 (2019) happened before lockdowns. The attendance had already fallen from 80,000 to 44,000 in the years before any pandemic existed. The pandemic did not create the decline; it accelerated it, bringing attendance to 5,000 in 2020 to 2021 when the center was actually closed. So the story is not "COVID killed the community center", it is "the community center was already dying, and COVID made that death visible."

Same with permits: construction boomed in 2018 to 2019, paused in 2020 to 2021 (normal pandemic disruption everywhere), then resumed in 2022+ at lower levels. Whether this lower level is permanent or a temporary adjustment? We do not know yet. You need years after recovery to understand that.

Beyond the COVID issue, there are other data limitations: Crime data does not tell us who commits crimes or who experiences them; the robber might be from somewhere else. Some crimes never get reported because people do not trust the system. Housing violations depend on inspections happening, which they did not during 2020 to 2021. Permits show what is built but not who is displaced. Air quality data is averaged, so we do not know if people near highways experience improvement equally or if it is temporary. The data shows trends. It shows patterns. It does not show causes. It does not show uneven impacts. It does not show the lived reality of being a person experiencing these changes. And it especially does not show normal patterns in 2020 to 2021, because those years were not normal.

This matters because it means: Trust the data when it shows you what happened. Crime numbers are real. Housing violations are real. Permits are real. But be humble about what it does not show you. Reality is always more complicated than the numbers. The real trends are 2016 to 2019 and 2022 to 2026. What happened between is an important context, but it is not a trend line. It is a disruption. Understanding the difference between a trend and a disruption is how you tell true stories about data.

Part VIII: Within the Broader Context

To understand the data, we need to know what is actually happening with people. The South Side historically was a place where the hard workers of the steel plants would live, raise their families, and have everything they would need. There was a bakery, a butcher, and many other essentials. But the South Side has changed from being a place for these families to primarily being a place for students and young professionals.

The data backs this up: while overall population has grown modestly (5% from 9,900 to 10,400 residents), the composition has shifted dramatically. Education levels have risen from 47% to 55% holding Bachelor degrees. The increase in young professionals and students reflects this shift. This is a massive change in who lives there, with different crime patterns, housing demands, and community patterns. Students do not tend to use community spaces, and do not tend to stay very long, vacating in the summer. Young professionals also fit this profile and move every few years. When a neighborhood primary population changes that dramatically, is it still the same neighborhood?

The permit activity data in this project is real. Money is being invested, buildings are being renovated, and infrastructure is being improved. Particularly in 2018 to 2019, there was a boom in development activity. On the surface that sounds good, but development

often comes with a cost for the people who are already living there. Landlords see opportunities to buy old buildings or vacant land, renovate/build, and raise the rent. They are banking on those students or young professionals paying more. Longtime residents, mostly the older population on fixed incomes or low-income families, get pushed out. The permits show the developments. They do not show the displacement, but both are happening simultaneously.

The South Side is being physically renewed for a new population while older residents are priced out. The South Side functions as a student housing and entertainment district, and it is not incidental to understanding the data. It is central; this is a space where people go to party. Where bars and restaurants cluster. Where the action happens on weekends. That function shapes who is there and when (mostly students and young professionals), what kind of crime shows up (entertainment district crimes, though notably, daytime and spread evenly rather than concentrated on weekends), police resources (more cops in entertainment zones), and how the neighborhood develops (buildings converted to student housing, bars opening, restaurants catering to young people).

But that function also shapes the data interpretation. The South Side is not trying to be a quiet residential neighborhood. It is functioning as designed, as a place for young people to live and socialize. But that design choice creates trade-offs. Weekend energy and nightlife (though with more daytime incidents than expected) mean transience, noise, and crime patterns typical of mixed-use districts. It means community institutions that serve families become irrelevant. It means the neighborhood to someone living there Monday through Friday is completely different from that of someone there Friday through

Sunday. If the Southside is functioning as an entertainment and young-professional district, should we judge it by residential neighborhood standards?

Part IX: The Reputation-Reality Gap; What It Means

The Southside carries a reputation as dangerous. Chaotic. A place defined by excess. Yet people who actually live there report feeling safe. Families have peaceful childhoods there. People build community there. This gap between reputation and lived experience is real. Both are true simultaneously. The gap exists because reputation and reality work differently.

Numbers feel more extreme than life actually is; you experience a neighborhood block by block, through relationships, not as statistics. Your actual risk depends on where you go, when, who you are with. Reputation sticks even when things change; people carry old stories forward. Crime data measures incidents, not safety; a place can have documented crime and still feel safe to people who know the spaces.

The Southside is mixed; some parts are busier during the day and especially on weekends (bars, restaurants), other blocks are quiet, some residents feel safe while others experience real risk. All at once. The child poverty rate spiking to 47% suggests real hardship for some families. At the same time, overall poverty has declined long-term to under 19%. The air is cleaner. But the community center has collapsed.

If lived experience and statistics do not contradict but actually coexist, what does that tell us about how to talk about neighborhood safety? Should reputation change when data changes? How do residents defend their actual experience against stereotypes supported by partial truths? What would it take for people outside the neighborhood to accept that both the crime data and the residents sense of safety are real?

For someone who grew up on the Southside and had to defend a safe childhood against stereotypes, this data validates something. Lived experience and numbers do not have to contradict. You can have crime and still feel safe. The neighborhood can have problems and still be somewhere people are okay. The data suggests the reputation might be bigger than the actual documented problems. But the reputation is not coming from nowhere. There is crime. The data just shows it is more specific and localized than the broad "it is dangerous" story.

If the data validates lived experience while also confirming some reputation-based concerns are real, what does that mean for residents trying to exist in that contradiction? How do people defend their actual experience while acknowledging real problems? What would neighborhoods and cities need to change to address the actual specific problems rather than responding to reputation?

When a neighborhood has specific, localized problems that are real but not neighborhood-wide disasters, how do we talk about that honestly? How do residents advocate for change without accepting that their neighborhood is "bad"? And how do we make sure that the people who have been there, like families living on quiet blocks, are not forgotten in the push for development and change?

Part X: Beyond the Headlines

Looking at crime, housing, development, environment, and community across a decade, the Southside story is not simple improvement or decline.

On crime: There is documented crime that shows daytime and weekly distribution (not the expected evening/weekend heavy pattern), with property crime dominating (not violent crime). Crime has actually been declining since the mid-2010s, with 2023

showing around 350 incidents after peaks of 1,200 to 1,500. Clearance rates are low for property crime, meaning most theft goes unsolved.

On housing: Old buildings with old problems, water damage, broken heating, deferred maintenance. Violations went up from 12,800 (2016) to 21,500 (2024), with pandemic disruption creating a backlog effect. Residents complain consistently with over 1,000 requests nearly every year, but that gap between complaints and solutions persists.

On development: Money being invested with permits spiking around 2018 to 2019, buildings renovated, infrastructure improved. But development also displaces, rents rise, longtime residents move out.

On environment: Air quality actually improved significantly, AQI dropped 50% from 21 to 11, that is the one clear positive trend.

On community: Community center attendance collapsed 87% from 80,000 (2017 peak) to 10,000, with the decline starting before the pandemic, suggesting structural demographic shifts.

All of that is true simultaneously. Housing violations are increasing while air quality improves. Development is happening while community institutions collapse. Crime patterns show daytime peaks and weekly distribution, but residents still feel safe in some areas and experience real risk in others. There is no single "Southside story." The neighborhood is experiencing multiple contradictory changes.

Development is displacing residents. The air is getting cleaner. Housing problems persist. Community institutions disappear. Some residents thrive in the new version of the neighborhood. Others struggle with displacement. Some maintain community despite transitions. Some discover the neighborhood is safer and more stable than they expected.

It is messy. We came into this project looking for a single answer, and what we found instead is that the answer depends entirely on what you measure and who you ask.

The data provides facts. Crime incidents are documented. Housing violations are recorded. Permits are filed. Air quality is measured. Community center attendance is counted. Development is happening. Displacement is happening. These are the observable facts across a decade. But facts alone do not answer the fundamental questions about the neighborhood. Is it safe? Is it changing for better or worse? Should residents stay or leave? Should development continue? Without answering these questions, the data alone does not tell us what to do.

And the data can support different conclusions depending on which facts matter most to whom. We realized we could not, and maybe should not, try to force a single conclusion from this data. Rather than trying to answer "Is the Southside safe?", maybe we should ask harder questions:

For whom is the Southside safe or unsafe? Students in bars during daytime business hours experience something different than longtime residents on quiet blocks. People working retail in the neighborhood experience something different than visiting students. What does safety mean for each group?

When and where does risk concentrate? Weekday patterns differ from the overall average. Certain blocks have higher incidents than others. Does understanding this specificity change what interventions make sense?

How have things changed and why? Crime declined from peaks of 1,500 down to 350. Housing violations increased from 12,800 to 21,500 (with pandemic disruption in the middle). Community centers emptied from 80,000 to 10,000. Development boomed

around 2018 to 2019. Air quality improved 50%. These changes happened for reasons. Understanding why matters more than just knowing they happened.

How does reputation shape what actually happens? Does being known as dangerous attract certain people and behavior? Or does reputation just distort how people perceive normal variation? Can a neighborhood reputation become a self-fulfilling prophecy?

What does the neighborhood need? Better policing for the specific crimes that occur? Housing repair and landlord accountability? Community building focused on students and young professionals (since that is who lives there now)? Support for longtime residents? Development that includes housing for existing residents? These questions do not have simple answers. But asking them specifically is better than broad generalizations.

Conclusion

The reputation for chaos is partly real, there is documented crime, and housing problems are significant. But reputation is exaggerated and distorted compared to what people actually experience most of the time. Someone spending weekdays in a residential area experiences a different neighborhood than the overall statistics might suggest. Someone on a quiet block experiences something different than someone in an active corridor.

The Southside is simultaneously a destination for young people and a home. A place where documented crime happens and where many people feel safe. A neighborhood with real problems and also real stability. The Southside deserves to be understood not through stereotypes or simple narratives, but through careful attention to what the data actually shows: complexity, contradiction, change happening in multiple directions simultaneously. It deserves respect for the actual people living through these changes,

some thriving in the new version of the neighborhood, some struggling with displacement, some maintaining community despite transitions, some discovering the neighborhood is safer and more stable than they expected.

For Delilah, growing up on the Southside meant spending years defending a safe childhood against a reputation that did not match her lived experience. When people heard she grew up there, they responded with surprise, as if safety and the Southside could not coexist. That gap between what she actually experienced and what people assumed about her neighborhood is what drove this entire project.

For Mackenzie, watching the Southside transform over years of visits, seeing new construction everywhere, wondering about the people being displaced, and noticing the changes while commuting through the city, raised urgent questions about who benefits from development and who pays the cost. Her work on air quality changes in different neighborhoods gave her a lens for understanding progress while also asking: who gets to experience that progress?

Together, we wanted to understand what the data actually says. Not to defend the neighborhood or prove the reputation wrong, but to sit with the complexity that we both know is real. This data confirms something we both understood from different angles: the truth is far more complex than the simple story people tell.

The Southside is not "good" or "bad." It is a neighborhood experiencing multiple changes simultaneously, some positive, some troubling, many contradictory. It is a place where crime statistics coexist with actual safety. Where development creates new opportunities and displacement. Where air quality improves while community institutions collapse. That complexity is harder to talk about than reputation, but it is closer to true.

Understanding it requires sitting with that complexity. Acknowledging real crime problems while recognizing they are distributed differently than the entertainment district stereotype suggests. Recognizing housing problems while understanding they are typical of older neighborhoods without landlord investment. Celebrating air quality improvement while questioning who gets to experience that improvement. Acknowledging development while asking whose interests it serves. Understanding community collapse while asking what could replace it.

That is harder than the simple reputation. But it is closer to the truth.